13.4.1 Types of Immunity

The term immunity (Latin immunis, free of burden) refers to the general ability of a host to resist infection or disease. There are two interdependent components of the immune response to invading microorganisms and foreign material. They are non-specific immune response or innate immunity or natural immunity and specific immune response or acquired immunity or adaptive immunity.

I. Innate immunity

Innate immunity refers to those general defence mechanisms that are inherited as part of the innate structure and function of each animal (such as skin, mucus and lysozyme). Innate immunity is the first line of defence against any microorganism or foreign material encountered by the vertebrate host. Innate immunity defends against foreign invaders equally and lacks immunological memory.

II. Acquired immunity

Acquired immunity refers to the type of specific immunity that develops after exposure to a suitable antigen (Figure 13.17). The effectiveness of acquired immunity increases on repeated exposure to foreign

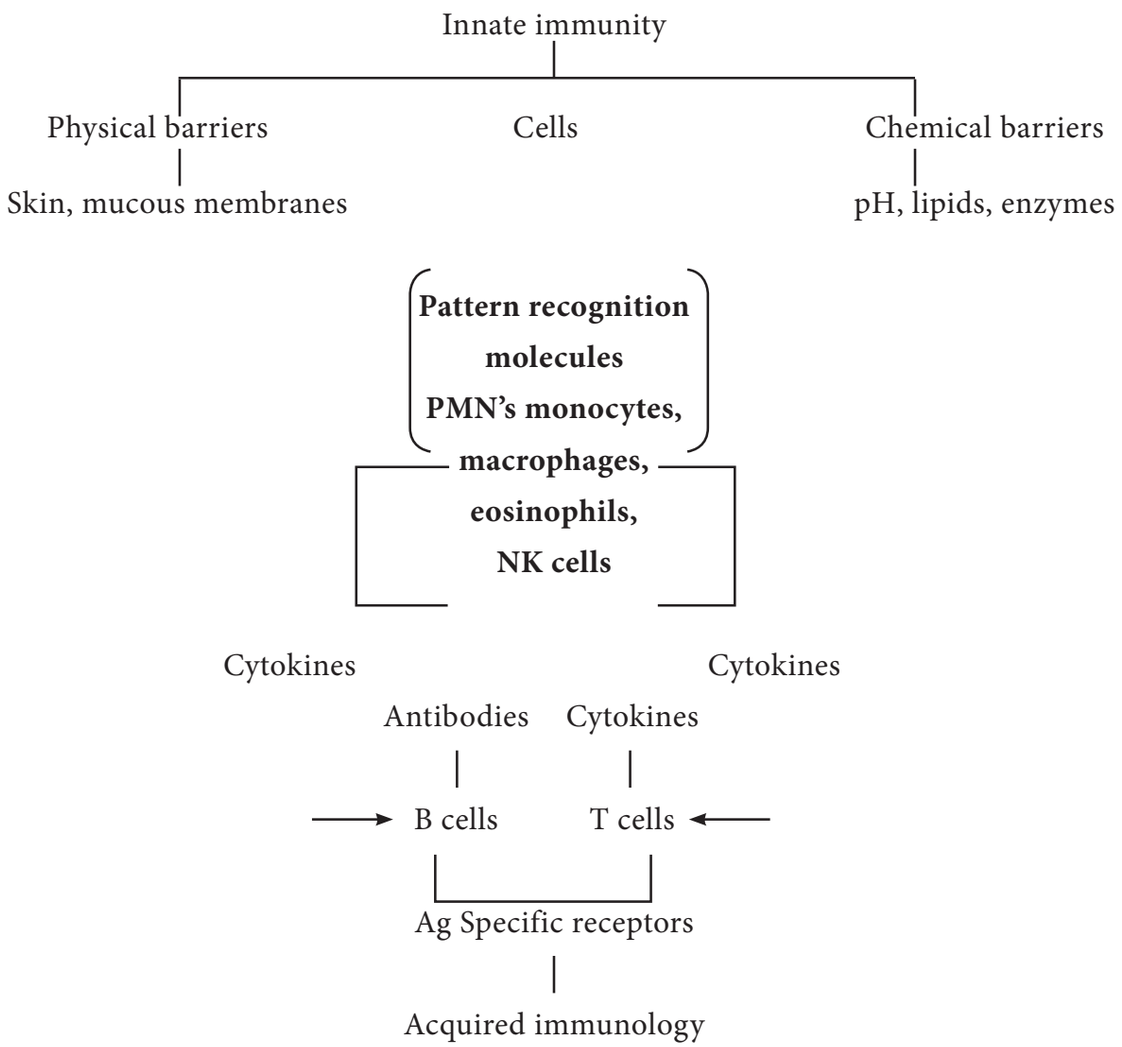

Figure 13.17: The interrelationship between innate and acquired immunity

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